

How to Remove Adware from Your Android Phone

A simple step-by-step guide. No factory reset. No lost photos.

The problem

Full-screen ads keep popping up on your phone. They get in the way all day, and the phone is almost impossible to use.

The usual fix (and why it hurts)

A **factory reset** wipes your phone. You lose photos, contacts, notes and app data.

A better way

Use your computer to find the hidden bad app and remove it. The tool is called **ADB** (Android Debug Bridge). It is free and made by Google. **All your personal data stays safe.**

What You Need

- A **Windows computer**
- A **USB cable** that can move data (not a charge-only cable)
- The **affected Android phone**
- About **15 to 20 minutes**

Part 1: Get Ready

Step 1 Download Google's ADB tool

ADB lets your computer send commands to your phone. Always download it from Google's official website.

1. Search online for **Android SDK Platform-Tools** and open the official Android Developer website.
2. Download the **ZIP file for Windows**.
3. Right-click the ZIP file and choose **Extract All**.
4. Save the extracted folder on your **Desktop** so it is easy to find.
5. Open the folder and check that you can see a file called **adb.exe**.

Step 2 Unlock Developer Options on your phone

Android hides some advanced settings by default. You need to switch them on.

1. Open **Settings** on your phone.
2. Go to **About Device**, then **Version** (some brands call it **Software Information**).
3. Find **Build Number** (or **Version No.**) and tap it quickly **7 times**.
4. You will see a message that Developer Mode is now on.

Part 2: Connect Your Phone to Your Computer

Step 3 Turn on USB Debugging

1. Go back to the main **Settings** menu.
2. Open **Additional Settings** (or **System**), then tap **Developer Options**.
3. Scroll down and switch on **USB Debugging**. Tap **OK** on the warning.
4. **Oppo / Realme (ColorOS) only:** scroll further and switch on **Disable Permission Monitoring**.

Step 4 Open a command window on your computer

1. Open the **platform-tools** folder on your Desktop.
2. Click the empty space in the **address bar** at the top of the window.
3. Type **cmd** and press **Enter**.
4. A black window opens. **Keep it open**. This is where you will type commands.

Step 5 Connect and allow your computer

1. Plug your phone into the computer with the USB cable. If the phone asks for a USB mode, choose **File Transfer**.
2. In the black window, type the command below and press Enter:

```
adb devices
```

3. Look at your phone right away. A box will ask **“Allow USB Debugging?”**. Tick **“Always allow from this computer”** and tap **Allow**.
4. Type **adb devices** again. You should now see a long code followed by the word **device**. This means you are connected.

Part 3: Find the Bad App

Adware hides its icon so you cannot see it on your home screen. But your phone still knows it is there. Every app has a hidden ID called a **package name**. It looks like this: **com.company.appname**. We need to find the package name of the bad app.

Step 6 Method A: Catch the ad while it is showing

This is the fastest way. Wait until an ad pops up on your phone. **While the ad is on the screen**, type this command on your computer and press Enter:

```
adb shell dumpsys activity activities | findstr "mResumedActivity"
```

The result shows one line with the name of the app that is showing the ad. The package name is the part that looks like **com.xxx.yyy** (it ends before any "/" sign). **Write it down.**

Tip

If you see names like **com.android.chrome** or your phone maker's launcher, the ad was not running at that moment. Try again when the ad is on the screen.

Step 7 Method B: Check the list of your apps

If Method A did not work, look through the apps you installed yourself. Type this command:

```
adb shell pm list packages -3
```

This shows only the apps **you or someone else installed** (not built-in phone apps). Read the list slowly and look for names that seem strange. Write down any you do not remember installing.

How to spot adware

Adware tries to look normal. Watch out for these tricks:

Trick	Example package names
Fake "cleaner" or "booster" apps	com.cleanmaster.security , com.battery.saver.pro
Extra PDF or document readers you never installed	com.document.readerx.viewer
Random gibberish names	com.xjf.lqo , com.abc.xyz

Not sure about a package name? Ask Google

You do not have to guess. You can check any name in under a minute:

1. In the black window, **highlight the package name** with your mouse, then **right-click** to copy it. You can also just type it out.
2. Open **Google** and **paste the name** into the search box. Adding the word **adware** or **what is** after it helps, for example: com.document.readerx.viewer adware
3. Read the first few results. If they say it is **adware, malware, or a source of pop-up ads**, it is the culprit. Go to Step 8 to remove it.
4. If the results show a **well-known app from a trusted company** (like Google, Samsung, or a bank you use), **leave it alone** and check the next name on your list.

Still not sure? Write down the names that look strange and check them one by one. Ask a friend or family member who knows phones, or visit a phone shop for help before you remove anything.

Part 4: Remove the Bad App

Step 8 Uninstall it with one command

Now you know the package name. In this example we use **com.document.readerx.viewer**. Replace it with your own package name.

```
adb shell pm uninstall -k --user 0 com.document.readerx.viewer
```

If the command worked, the window will show one word: **Success**. Then **restart your phone**.

Be careful

Only remove apps that you are sure are bad. If you are not sure, **copy the package name and search for it on Google first** (see Step 7).

If you see **Failure**, check that you typed the package name exactly right.

When you are finished, go back to Developer Options and switch **USB Debugging** off again.

Part 5: Stop It from Happening Again

Step 9 Lock down your phone

1. Switch on AdGuard DNS (recommended)

Why we love this one

AdGuard DNS blocks ads, trackers and dangerous websites **across your whole phone**. That includes your browser, your apps and games. It also helps stop fake “Your phone has a virus!” pop-ups. It takes about one minute to set up and you do not need to install anything.

How to turn it on:

1. Open **Settings**, then go to **Connection & sharing** (or **Network & internet**).
2. Tap **Private DNS**.
3. Choose **Private DNS provider hostname** (may be called “Designated private DNS”).
4. Type exactly: **dns.adguard-dns.com**
5. Tap **Save**. Done!

Good to know: Private DNS works on Android 9 and newer. Want extra protection for kids? Use **family.adguard-dns.com** instead. It also blocks adult websites.

2. Turn off “Install unknown apps”

Go to **Settings > Apps > Special app access > Install unknown apps**. Make sure every app is switched **OFF**, especially **Chrome**, **WhatsApp** and your **File Manager**. This stops bad apps from sneaking onto your phone.

3. Limit “Display over other apps”

Adware uses this permission to put ads on top of everything. Go to **Settings > Apps > Special app access > Display over other apps** and switch it **OFF** for apps that do not need it.

4. Check Google Play Protect

Open the **Google Play Store**, tap your **profile picture**, then tap **Play Protect**. Tap the **gear icon** at the top right and make sure **Scan apps with Play Protect** is switched **ON**.

Final advice

Do **not** download “RAM Boosters”, “Battery Savers” or “Antivirus Cleaners” from developers you do not know. Modern Android phones already have these features built in, and they are safe. Most adware hides inside this kind of app.

Quick Checklist

Done?	Task
☐	Downloaded Platform-Tools from the official Android website
☐	Turned on Developer Options and USB Debugging, then connected the phone
☐	Found the bad app’s package name (checked it on Google if unsure)
☐	Removed it and restarted the phone
☐	Switched on AdGuard DNS (dns.adguard-dns.com)
☐	Turned off “Install unknown apps” and checked Google Play Protect is on